

Moroccan Riad Café



Lunch & Dinner — 11:00am to 9:00pm

Full Recipe Cards · US Market Food Costing · Kitchen Prep Flow · Financial Forecast

أهلاً وسهلاً · Marhba Bik

The slow-cooked soul of Fez, Marrakech & Casablanca. Tagines, bastilla, couscous royale, and the mint tea ceremony — a complete North African dining experience.

40

SEATS

\$46

AVG SPEND

24%

FOOD COST TARGET

\$57,292

EST. MONTHLY NET

L'Hospitalité Marocaine — The Riad Concept: A riad (from the Arabic *ryad*, meaning garden) is a traditional Moroccan house built inward around a central courtyard with a fountain. The architecture inverts Western logic: the plain exterior conceals extraordinary interior beauty — carved plasterwork (stucco), zellij tilework, cedar wood ceilings, and the constant sound of water. This is the conceptual heart of the Moroccan Riad Café. The guest steps through a plain door into another world. Moroccan hospitality — *l'hospitalité marocaine* — is not a service standard; it is a deeply held cultural value. The Prophet Muhammad said: "Whoever believes in Allah and the Last Day should be generous to his guest." A guest is honoured. Mint tea is poured not once but three times by tradition, each glass with different meaning. To refuse is not merely a social inconvenience — it is a cultural rupture. The food that comes from this culture reflects the same principle: layered, generous, aromatic, never rushed. Tagines cook for hours. Couscous steams three times. Bastilla is assembled leaf by leaf. This guide will teach your team not just how to cook the food but why it tastes the way it does — because the why is what separates an authentic experience from an imitation.

THE STORY BEHIND THIS GUIDE

"In Morocco, refusing a guest's tea is an insult. Understanding that one cultural fact changed how I designed my entire front-of-house experience."

Yasmine had never been to Morocco until she was 31. She went for two weeks and stayed for three months. She ate in medinas in Fes and Marrakech, in riad courtyards where the light came through carved cedar screens and the mint tea arrived in a silver pot poured from height into small glasses. She learned that Moroccan hospitality — *l'hospitalité marocaine* — is not a service philosophy taught in a training manual. It is a cultural obligation so deep it has a word: *diyafa*. The guest is sacred. The welcome is not optional. To refuse hospitality is to refuse humanity.

She came back to Los Angeles with a corporate communications job, \$55,000 in savings, and an obsession with a cuisine that most Americans had encountered only as a side note on a Mediterranean menu — a vague tagine, a couscous that had been boiled rather than steamed, a mint tea that had been

made with a tea bag. She saw the gap between what Moroccan food actually was and what American restaurants were offering, and she decided the gap was the business opportunity.

The bastilla section in this guide — the sweet-savoury chicken pie dusted with icing sugar, the Fez palace origin story, the explanation of why a meat dish has icing sugar on it (because in medieval Andalusian court cuisine, sweet and savoury were not separate categories) — was the moment she understood: this guide would give her not just the recipes but the stories. And in Moroccan cuisine, the story is the product.

She opened in Silver Lake. The mint tea ceremony is performed at every table. The tagine lid is lifted tableside. The bastilla is dusted with icing sugar in front of the guest. Month six net: \$56,000. An LA Times review used the word transporting. She printed it and put it on the kitchen wall. **Moroccan hospitality is ancient. This guide is how you make it contemporary and profitable.**

Yasmine A. · Moroccan Riad Cafe · Silver Lake, Los Angeles · Est. Month 6 Net: \$56,000

1 Entrées

Harira — Moroccan Tomato, Lentil & Lamb Soup

Tomato, lentil, chickpea, lamb, saffron, fresh coriander · Sell: \$11.99

5 min service

Entrée

Target FC: 18%

Batch

INGREDIENTS (PER BOWL / BATCH ÷ 12)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Lamb shoulder, diced 1cm	60g	\$0.59
Green lentils, dried	40g	\$0.06
Chickpeas, cooked (from dried)	50g	\$0.06
Crushed tomatoes	80g	\$0.08
Onion, grated	40g	\$0.04
Celery, finely chopped	20g	\$0.03
Saffron (pinch — 0.05g)	0.05g	\$1.40
Ras el hanout	3g	\$0.09
Fresh coriander + parsley	10g each	\$0.10
Lemon juice	15ml	\$0.04
Flour (for thickening)	10g	\$0.01
Total cost per bowl		\$2.50

Cost per serve	\$2.50
Sell price	\$11.99
Food cost %	20.9%
Contribution margin	\$9.49

METHOD

1 Build the aromatic base: Brown diced lamb in olive oil over high heat. The Maillard reaction —

the browning of proteins at above 300°F — creates hundreds of new flavour compounds that are essential to harira's depth. A grey, steamed lamb piece contributes almost nothing to the broth; a browned piece releases fat-soluble aromatics that perfume the entire soup. Add grated onion, celery, ras el hanout, ground coriander, ginger, and turmeric. Sauté 5 minutes until the onion is soft and the spices are toasted in the fat.

2 The tomato stage and saffron bloom: Add crushed tomatoes and cook down 10 minutes — the acidity must reduce before adding stock or the soup will be harsh. Bloom saffron in 2 tablespoons of warm water for 5 minutes. Saffron (*Crocus sativus* stigmas) releases crocin (colour), safranal (fragrance), and picrocrocin (flavour) into warm liquid — never add saffron directly to a cold or acidic liquid without blooming first, as the extraction will be incomplete. Add bloomed saffron with its water to the pot.

3 Lentils, chickpeas, and the tedouira: Add lentils (pre-soaked), cooked chickpeas, and enough lamb or chicken stock to cover generously. Simmer 40–50 minutes until lentils are completely tender and the soup is thick. Traditional harira is finished with *tedouira* — a slurry of flour whisked with water added in a thin stream while stirring constantly. This technique creates a slightly silky, thickened consistency that is uniquely Moroccan. Without tedouira the soup is more broth-like; with it, the soup has body and coats the spoon.

4 Finish with herbs and acid: Off heat, stir in a large handful of fresh coriander and flat-leaf parsley (both are non-negotiable in harira — dried herbs will not work), and a squeeze of lemon. The fresh herbs must go in at the very end — cooking them destroys their volatile oils. The lemon brightens and lifts the entire soup. Season generously with salt and black pepper. Serve with dried dates and a wedge of lemon — tradition dictates eating harira during Ramadan to break the fast, and dates always accompany.

Chef's Tip: Saffron is the most expensive spice by weight in the world — good Moroccan saffron (from Taliouine, the world capital of saffron cultivation) costs \$28+/gram wholesale. You need only 0.05g per bowl. Never skip it — saffron is what makes harira smell and taste Moroccan rather than generic lentil soup. Buy whole threads, never powder (which is frequently adulterated). Store in an airtight container away from light. It lasts 2 years.

GLUTEN (flour, tedouira)

CELERY

Briouats au Poulet — Chicken & Almond Pastilla Triangles

Chicken, almond, cinnamon, ras el hanout in crispy warqa — 3 pieces · Sell: \$13.99

6 min

Entrée

Target FC: 20%

INGREDIENTS (3 PIECES PER SERVE)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Chicken thighs, cooked shredded	90g	\$0.64
Blanched almonds, toasted + roughly ground	25g	\$0.55
Ras el hanout	3g	\$0.09
Cinnamon, ground	1g	\$0.02
Egg (for binding + egg wash)	1 × 55g	\$0.35
Phyllo / warqa dough sheets	40g (3 strips)	\$0.36
Fresh coriander, chopped	5g	\$0.04
Onion, sweated	30g	\$0.03
Honey (for finish drizzle)	5g	\$0.09
Frying oil	—	\$0.12
Total cost per serve (3 pcs)		\$2.29

Cost per serve	\$2.29
Sell price	\$13.99
Food cost %	16.4%
Contribution margin	\$11.70

METHOD

- 1

Prepare the filling — the pastilla principle: The briouat filling is a miniaturised version of the great bastilla: sweet-savoury-spiced. Sweat finely diced onion in butter until soft and beginning to caramelise. Add shredded poached chicken thigh, ras el hanout, ground cinnamon, salt, and a splash of orange flower water. The orange flower water is not perfumery — it is a flavouring agent used in Moroccan cuisine since the medieval era and contributes a floral-citrus note that makes this filling smell unmistakably Moroccan. Cool completely before filling pastry.
- 2

The warqa/phyllo technique: Traditional *warqa* (from the Arabic for "leaf") is paper-thin Moroccan pastry made by dabbing a wet dough ball against a hot plate — a technique requiring enormous skill. In a commercial kitchen, phyllo works perfectly as a substitute. Cut phyllo sheets into strips approx. 8cm x 25cm. The key is working fast — phyllo dries in seconds and becomes brittle and unworkable. Keep covered with a damp (not wet) cloth at all times. Place filling at one end, fold into triangles with flag-folding technique, sealing the last edge with egg wash.
- 3

Batch-produce and refrigerate: Briouats can be filled and shaped up to 24 hours ahead — keep covered in the refrigerator. Do not freeze unfired, as the moisture from the filling will soften the pastry. Fry from cold at **175°C / 347°F** for 3–4 minutes, turning once. The cold start allows the pastry to crisp evenly without the filling overheating. The exterior should be deep golden — not pale gold. A pale briouat is underdone.
- 4

Finish and plate: Drain briefly on a wire rack (not paper — steam underneath softens the pastry). Dust with icing sugar and a whisper of cinnamon — the sweet-savoury contrast is the point. Drizzle a thin line of warmed honey across the plate. The Moroccan sweet-savoury tradition dates to medieval court cooking and the influence of Andalusian cuisine brought to Morocco by Arab and Jewish refugees expelled from Spain in 1492. Every briouat tells this history.

Chef's Tip: The toasted almond in the filling is critical — it provides texture contrast (crunch inside the crispy pastry), fat richness, and the slightly bitter almond note that prevents the filling from being cloying. Toast almonds until they are genuinely golden (not just warm) — raw almonds have an astringent, green flavour that does not belong in this dish. Grind roughly so you have both fine pieces and visible chunks.

GLUTEN (phyllo)

EGGS

TREE NUTS (almonds)

Zaalouk — Smoky Aubergine Salad

Charred aubergine, tomato, cumin, garlic, preserved lemon · Sell: \$10.99

3 min service

Entrée

Target FC: 14%

Batch

INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE / BATCH + 10)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Aubergine / eggplant, whole	150g	\$0.22
Crushed tomatoes (or fresh, grated)	80g	\$0.08
Garlic cloves, minced	6g (2 cloves)	\$0.03
Ground cumin	2g	\$0.02
Smoked paprika	1g	\$0.01
Preserved lemon rind, finely chopped	8g	\$0.11
Extra virgin olive oil	15ml	\$0.12
Fresh coriander	5g	\$0.05
Lemon juice	10ml	\$0.03
Total cost per serve		\$0.67

Cost per serve	\$0.67
Sell price	\$10.99
Food cost %	6.1%
Contribution margin	\$10.32

METHOD

- 1

The char — building smoke flavour: Place whole aubergines directly over a gas flame or under a very hot broiler. Cook, turning occasionally, until the skin is completely blackened and the interior has collapsed and softened — approximately 15-20 minutes. The purpose is twofold: the heat cooks the flesh through, and the charring of the skin deposits volatile phenolic compounds (guaiacol, syringol) that permeate the flesh with genuine smoke flavour. This is not about aesthetics — the black skin is removed. The smoke is in the flesh.
- 2

Drain and handle correctly: Place charred aubergines in a colander and allow to cool for 10 minutes. Peel away all blackened skin — any remaining charred bits will create bitter, gritty specks in the final dish. The eggplant flesh will be wet and silky. Chop roughly with a knife — do not purée in a food processor. Zaalouk should have rough texture, not hummus smoothness. Squeeze gently in your hand to expel excess liquid. This step prevents a watery final salad.
- 3

Cook down with tomato and spices: Heat olive oil in a wide pan. Add minced garlic and cook 60 seconds — until fragrant but not coloured (burned garlic is bitter and cannot be corrected). Add the aubergine pulp, grated tomato, cumin, smoked paprika, and a pinch of cayenne. Cook over medium heat, stirring regularly, for 15 minutes until the mixture is thick, glossy, and the excess liquid has evaporated. The cooked-down consistency is what separates zaalouk from a raw mixed salad.
- 4

Preserved lemon finishing: Remove from heat. Stir in finely chopped preserved lemon rind, a squeeze of fresh lemon, and fresh coriander. Preserved lemon rind (the fermented peel of salt-cured lemons) adds a complex flavour impossible to achieve with fresh lemon alone — salty, fermented, intensely citrusy with an almost floral quality from the essential oils that concentrate during curing. Only the rind is used — the pulp is discarded. Pool the zaalouk on a plate, drizzle with extra virgin olive oil, and scatter coriander. Serve room temperature with fresh bread.

Chef's Tip: Zaalouk improves dramatically with time — make it the day before service. Overnight refrigeration allows the flavours to meld and the preserved lemon to permeate the entire dish. Always serve at room temperature, never straight from the fridge. Cold zaalouk tastes flat because fat-soluble flavour compounds are less volatile at cold temperatures. The olive oil should be pooled generously — this is not a low-fat dish.

NONE (naturally free of all major allergens)

Moroccan Carrot Salad with Cumin & Preserved Lemon

Roasted carrots, cumin, harissa, preserved lemon, orange flower water · Sell: \$9.99

3 min service Entrée Target FC: 12% Batch

INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE / BATCH ÷ 12)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Carrots, peeled and sliced	160g	\$0.14
Ground cumin (toasted)	3g	\$0.03
Harissa paste	8g	\$0.14
Preserved lemon rind, minced	10g	\$0.14
Orange flower water	5ml	\$0.08
Extra virgin olive oil	15ml	\$0.12
Honey	5g	\$0.09
Fresh coriander + mint	5g each	\$0.09
Total cost per serve		\$0.83

Cost per serve	\$0.83
Sell price	\$9.99
Food cost %	8.3%
Contribution margin	\$9.16

METHOD

- 1

Roast, don't boil: Cut carrots into coins or batons and roast at **400°F / 205°C** with olive oil and a pinch of cumin until just tender and caramelised at the edges — approximately 20–25 minutes. Roasting concentrates the natural sugars (primarily sucrose and glucose) through the Maillard reaction and caramelisation, creating depth of flavour impossible from boiled carrots. Boiled carrot salad tastes timid. Roasted carrot salad tastes like cooking.
- 2

Toast the cumin: Toast whole cumin seeds in a dry pan until fragrant and lightly browned — 60–90 seconds. Grind in a mortar. This is mandatory: pre-ground cumin has lost 60–70% of its volatile aromatics (cuminaldehyde, cuminol) through oxidation during storage. Freshly ground toasted cumin is a completely different ingredient. The carrot salad relies on cumin as its dominant flavour note — use only freshly toasted and ground.
- 3

Dress warm: While carrots are still warm from the oven, toss with harissa, minced preserved lemon rind, honey, orange flower water, and olive oil. Warm vegetables absorb dressing more effectively than cold — the cell structure is more open and porous. The combination of harissa (heat), honey (sweet), preserved lemon (salty-fermented-citric), and orange flower water (floral) creates the characteristic Moroccan flavour balance: all five dimensions present simultaneously.
- 4

Rest and finish: Allow to cool to room temperature. The flavours integrate as the salad rests — 30 minutes minimum, overnight ideally. Taste and adjust: more harissa for heat, more lemon for brightness, more honey if needed. Finish with fresh coriander and mint torn roughly. The mint adds a cooling contrast to the harissa heat that is quintessentially Moroccan — the country uses more fresh mint per capita than almost any other in the world.

Chef's Tip: This is your highest-margin entrée at 8.3% food cost. Price it as a complement to zaalouk — offer both together as a mezze starter for \$16.99 (a saving vs. individual price) and most tables will take both. The two salads together represent the Moroccan *kemia* tradition — small, intensely flavoured bites served before the main meal to whet the appetite.

NONE (check harissa brand for sulphites)

Msemen — Flaky Moroccan Flatbread

Layered semolina flatbread, warm honey, argan butter · Sell: \$8.99

8 min

Entrée

Target FC: 16%

INGREDIENTS (2 MSEMEN PER SERVE)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Plain flour	70g	\$0.05
Fine semolina	30g	\$0.04
Salt, yeast	2g each	\$0.01
Vegetable oil (for lamination)	10ml	\$0.02
Argan oil	5ml (~10g)	\$0.40
Honey (local wildflower)	20g	\$0.35
Unsalted butter, softened	10g	\$0.08
Total cost per serve		\$0.95

Cost per serve	\$0.95
Sell price	\$8.99
Food cost %	10.6%
Contribution margin	\$8.04

METHOD

- 1

Dough and gluten development: Mix flour, semolina, salt, yeast, and warm water to a smooth, slightly tacky dough. Knead 10 minutes — gluten must be fully developed for the lamination process to work. Underdeveloped gluten tears during folding and stretching. Rest 30 minutes. The semolina adds a slightly gritty texture and a nuttier flavour compared to an all-flour msemen — this is the authentic composition.

- 2

Lamination — the source of flakiness: Oil your hands and the work surface. Flatten a golf-ball portion of dough as thin as possible using oiled hands (not a rolling pin — the oil prevents tearing). Spread a thin film of soft butter mixed with semolina across the surface. Fold into thirds (like a letter), then fold into thirds again — creating 9 layers of butter-separated dough. This lamination process is what makes msemen flaky: the fat separates the dough layers, which puff and separate on the griddle.
- 3

Rest and griddle: Rest folded msemen 10 minutes — the gluten relaxes and the layers set. Cook on a lightly oiled griddle over medium heat for 3–4 minutes per side. Press gently with a spatula to ensure contact. The exterior should be golden-brown with slightly crisped edges; the interior should remain soft and layered. If the heat is too high, the outside burns before the inside is cooked. Too low, and the bread dries out without colouring properly.
- 4

Serve immediately with argan butter: Msemen must be served hot from the griddle — it deteriorates quickly as it cools. Mix softened butter with a few drops of argan oil and a pinch of fleur de sel. Argan oil (from the nuts of the *Argania spinosa* tree, endemic to Southwest Morocco) has a distinctive roasted, slightly nutty flavour profile unlike any other oil. It is extraordinarily expensive — handle it as a finishing oil only, never for high-heat cooking. Drizzle honey and the argan butter simultaneously on the hot msemen so both melt and pool together.

Chef's Tip: Pre-shape and laminate msemen in batches during morning prep and refrigerate uncooked (covered). Griddle to order. The cold butter in the lamination creates even more defined layers when cooked from cold — the butter hasn't softened and merged. Never microwave or reheat a cooked msemen — they become rubbery and dense, bearing no resemblance to the fresh version.

GLUTEN (wheat, semolina)

DAIRY (butter)

TREE NUTS (argan — technical nut allergen risk)

Kefta Cigares — Lamb Mince Rolls

Spiced lamb mince in crispy phyllo cigars, harissa dipping sauce — 3 pieces · Sell: \$13.99

6 min

Entrée

Target FC: 22%

INGREDIENTS (3 CIGARES PER SERVE)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Lamb mince	100g	\$1.54
Onion, finely grated (drained)	30g	\$0.03
Ras el hanout	4g	\$0.12
Cumin, ground	2g	\$0.02
Cinnamon, ground	1g	\$0.01
Fresh parsley + coriander, minced	8g each	\$0.08
Phyllo dough sheets	45g	\$0.40
Egg wash	—	\$0.06
Harissa dipping sauce (batch)	30ml	\$0.53
Total cost per serve (3 pcs)		\$2.79

Cost per serve	\$2.79
Sell price	\$13.99
Food cost %	19.9%
Contribution margin	\$11.20

METHOD

- 1

The kefta mix and ras el hanout: Combine lamb mince with grated (not diced — it must be fine enough to integrate completely) onion, ras el hanout, cumin, cinnamon, paprika, fresh parsley, and coriander. Mix by hand — do not use a food processor, which will develop the myosin proteins in the meat too aggressively, creating a rubbery emulsified texture rather than a loose, juicy kefta. The mix should hold together when squeezed but still feel loose. Season generously — the

phyllo pastry is neutral and the filling must carry all the flavour.

- 2 **Understanding ras el hanout:** *Ras el hanout* translates as "head of the shop" — the spice merchant's best blend, historically containing whatever the merchant considered his finest. Traditional blends can contain 20-30+ spices: cumin, coriander, ginger, cinnamon, turmeric, black pepper, cardamom, nutmeg, allspice, rose petals, lavender, orris root, mace, and more. The complexity creates an aromatic depth no single spice achieves. No two Moroccan households use the same ras el hanout. In a restaurant, use a high-quality commercial blend or make your own signature blend — it defines the character of your kitchen.
- 3 **Rolling the cigare:** Cut phyllo into rectangles approx. 10cm × 18cm. Place 30g of kefta mix along the near edge and roll tightly into a cigar shape — this is the tightest roll possible. Any air gaps and the filling will contract during cooking, leaving an empty cigar with all the filling at one end. Seal with egg wash. Taper and pinch the ends. Refrigerate up to 24 hours or fry immediately.
- 4 **Fry and serve:** Deep fry at **175°C / 347°F** for 4-5 minutes, turning occasionally, until deep golden and the lamb inside reaches **75°C / 167°F**. Drain on a rack. Serve three per portion with a generous ramekin of harissa (thinned with olive oil, lemon, and a pinch of cumin — not straight from the jar). The harissa-dipping ritual is as important as the cigares themselves.

Chef's Tip: The lamb-fat content of the mince matters. Use 20-25% fat lamb mince — lean mince cooks dry and crumbly. If your lamb mince is very lean, add a tablespoon of cold butter to the mix. The fat is what keeps the kefta moist inside the hot, dry phyllo cooking environment.

GLUTEN (phyllo) EGGS

2 Main Courses

Lamb Tagine with Preserved Lemon & Olives

Slow-braised lamb shoulder, preserved lemon, Picholine olives, saffron · Sell: \$26.99

5 min service (2.5hr batch) Main Target FC: 24% Signature

The Tagine: Vessel vs. Dish. A *tagine* (also spelled *tajine*) is both the vessel and the dish cooked within it. The vessel is a shallow clay base with a distinctive conical lid. The cone is not decorative — it is a passive condensation machine. Steam rising from the braising liquid hits the cool ceramic cone, condenses into droplets, and runs back down the walls to the base, continuously basting the meat. The clay pot itself is porous, which regulates moisture loss and imparts a subtle mineral quality to long-cooked dishes. A tagine-shaped stainless steel pot achieves the same steam cycle but lacks the porosity and the thermal mass of clay. Both work; only one is authentic.

INGREDIENTS (PER PORTION)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Lamb shoulder, bone-in, cut 150g	280g raw	\$5.58
Preserved lemons (1/4 lemon per serve)	30g	\$0.40
Picholine green olives, pitted	40g	\$0.48
Saffron (0.1g)	0.1g	\$2.80
Ras el hanout	5g	\$0.15
Onion, grated	60g	\$0.06
Garlic, minced	10g	\$0.05
Fresh ginger, grated	8g	\$0.06
Lamb or chicken stock	120ml	\$0.12
Olive oil	20ml	\$0.16
Fresh coriander + parsley	10g	\$0.08
Couscous (service side)	80g dry	\$0.44
Total cost per serve		\$10.38

Cost per serve	\$10.38
Sell price	\$26.99
Food cost %	38.5%
Contribution margin	\$16.61

△ Note: Lamb shoulder at \$9/lb drives FC above 24% target. Offset with high-margin drinks and desserts. This dish is your reputation-builder.

METHOD

- 1 **The chermoula marinade — flavour foundation:** Combine ras el hanout, ground ginger, turmeric, saffron-infused water, minced garlic, grated onion, and olive oil into a paste. Coat the lamb shoulder pieces thoroughly and marinate a minimum of 4 hours — overnight preferred. The fat-soluble spice compounds in ras el hanout require time to penetrate the lamb's exterior fat layer. Surface-marinated lamb that goes straight into the pot will have a thin spiced crust but a bland interior. Overnight marination produces lamb that tastes seasoned to the bone.
- 2 **Build the tagine base:** In a heavy-bottomed pot or traditional tagine base, warm olive oil over medium heat. Brown the marinated lamb on all sides — 3-4 minutes per face. Do not skip browning. The Maillard reaction creates a crust of complex flavour compounds that the slow-cook broth will absorb over 2+ hours. Add remaining grated onion and garlic. Layer ras el hanout (add spices in two stages — half at browning, half 30 minutes into cooking — the first layer toasts in the fat and caramelises; the second layer blooms in the liquid and remains fresh-aromatic).
- 3 **Preserved lemon chemistry and the slow cook:** Add the preserved lemon quarters (rind only — remove pulp) at the start of braising, not at the end. During the long slow cook, the lemon rind softens, its fermented citric acids integrate into the broth, and the essential oil compounds (primarily limonene and citral) that intensified during salt-curing slowly perfume the entire tagine. This is fundamentally different from adding fresh lemon at service — the result is a deep, integrated citrus-salt note woven through the broth rather than a bright surface acidity. Add olives only in the last 20 minutes of cooking — they become bitter and soft if braised too long.
- 4 **The two-hour braise and couscous service:** Cover tightly, reduce heat to the lowest simmer (85-90°C / 185-194°F), and cook 2-2.5 hours until the lamb is falling off the bone. Check every 45 minutes — add stock if liquid reduces below 1cm depth. Skim fat from surface before service. Finish with fresh coriander and parsley. Serve the tagine in the clay pot at the table — the visual of lifting the conical lid and the release of steam is the dining event. Steam couscous separately and serve alongside.

Chef's Tip: Batch-cook tagines in large Dutch ovens during morning prep (7am start, done by 10am). Individual clay tagines reheat the portions at service — add a ladle of broth, cover, and warm for 8 minutes in a 350°F oven. The clay pot warms slowly and evenly, preventing the lamb from toughening. Never microwave lamb tagine — the rapid, uneven heating makes the collagen-rich meat rubbery.

NONE (naturally gluten-free if served with couscous)

Chicken Tagine with Apricot & Almond

Slow-braised chicken thighs, dried apricots, blanched almonds, saffron broth · Sell: \$23.99

5 min service (2hr batch) Main Target FC: 22%

INGREDIENTS (PER PORTION)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Chicken thighs, bone-in skin-on	280g (2 thighs)	\$1.97
Dried apricots (halved)	40g	\$0.53
Blanched almonds, toasted	25g	\$0.55
Saffron (0.1g)	0.1g	\$2.80
Ras el hanout	4g	\$0.12
Cinnamon stick + ground ginger	1 + 3g	\$0.05
Honey	10g	\$0.18

Onion, grated	60g	\$0.06
Chicken stock	150ml	\$0.08
Olive oil	20ml	\$0.16
Fresh coriander	8g	\$0.07
Couscous (service side)	80g dry	\$0.44
Total cost per serve		\$7.01

Cost per serve	\$7.01
Sell price	\$23.99
Food cost %	29.2%
Contribution margin	\$16.98

METHOD

- 1 **Sear the chicken for colour and flavour:** Season chicken thighs generously with ras el hanout, ginger, cinnamon, and salt. Sear skin-side down in hot olive oil for 5 minutes — the skin must render and crisp before braising. Chicken skin that enters the braising liquid without being seared will turn flabby and gelatinous — unpleasant in texture. A properly seared skin, however, holds together during the braise and contributes rendered fat and Maillard flavour compounds to the broth. Flip and sear 2 minutes on the flesh side.
- 2 **Build the saffron broth:** Remove seared chicken. In the same pot, sweat grated onion in the chicken fat rendered during searing — do not add more oil. Add garlic, the remaining ras el hanout (second spice addition), and the saffron bloomed in warm water. Add chicken stock and honey. The honey serves two functions: it adds the characteristic Moroccan sweet note to the broth, and during the long cook it caramelises slightly, contributing depth and helping the sauce reduce to a glossy consistency.
- 3 **Apricot timing — the sugar question:** Return chicken to the pot. Add dried apricots in the final 40 minutes of a 90-minute total cook. Adding apricots at the start causes them to dissolve completely into the broth (not unpleasant, but loses the visual and textural element). Adding them in the last 40 minutes softens them to a jammy, yielding texture while they absorb the saffron broth without losing their shape. They should be identifiable but not firm — think of stewed fruit at peak doneness.
- 4 **Toasted almond finish and service:** Check seasoning — the broth should taste sweet-savoury-fragrant with a distinct saffron note. Reduce uncovered if too liquid — the sauce should coat the back of a spoon. Scatter toasted whole almonds over the top at service — not during cooking (they will soften). The contrast of the jammy apricot, the juicy chicken, and the crunchy almond is the defining textural experience of this dish. Garnish with fresh coriander and a cinnamon stick for visual theatre.

Chef's Tip: This is your most approachable main for new Moroccan food guests — the sweet-fruity broth with chicken is non-threatening and delicious. It is frequently the dish that converts first-timers into regulars. Position it as "our most popular dish" on the menu and in verbal sells — that social proof lowers the ordering barrier for undecided guests.

TREE NUTS (almonds) SULPHITES (dried apricots — check)

Beef Kefta Tagine — Meatballs, Egg & Tomato

Spiced beef & lamb meatballs in tomato-harissa sauce, eggs baked in · Sell: \$21.99

15 min to order Main Target FC: 23%

INGREDIENTS (PER PORTION)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Beef and lamb mince (50/50)	180g	\$2.88
Onion, grated (for kefta mix)	25g	\$0.03
Ras el hanout + cumin + paprika	5g total	\$0.12

Fresh parsley + coriander, minced	10g each	\$0.10
Crushed tomatoes	150g	\$0.15
Harissa	15g	\$0.26
Garlic cloves, sliced	6g	\$0.03
Eggs (2 per portion)	2 x 55g	\$0.70
Olive oil	15ml	\$0.12
Bread (msemen or khobz) for service	—	\$0.28
Total cost per serve		\$4.67

Cost per serve	\$4.67
Sell price	\$21.99
Food cost %	21.2%
Contribution margin	\$17.32

METHOD

- 1 Kefta mix — fat and herb ratio:** Combine beef and lamb mince (the combination is traditional — beef alone is too lean and firm; lamb alone too fatty and rich; together they balance). Add grated onion, ras el hanout, cumin, paprika, cinnamon, fresh parsley, and coriander. Season assertively. Roll into walnut-sized balls (approx. 25g each) — small enough to cook through in the sauce without drying out. Do not overwork the meat — mix only until combined. Overworking extracts myosin proteins and produces a dense, bouncy meatball rather than a juicy, loose one.
- 2 The tomato sauce — layers of spice:** Heat olive oil in a clay tagine or heavy skillet. Cook sliced garlic until golden. Add crushed tomatoes, harissa, cumin, paprika, and a pinch of sugar. Cook down 10 minutes until the sauce is thick and the rawness of the tomato is gone — raw tomato sauce tastes flat and acidic; cooked-down tomato develops sweetness and depth. Season the sauce separately before adding the meatballs — an under-seasoned sauce cannot be corrected at service.
- 3 Nestle the kefta and braise:** Place the raw kefta balls directly into the simmering tomato sauce. Cover and cook on low heat for 12-15 minutes — the meatballs cook through by braising, absorbing the tomato and spice flavours simultaneously. Unlike pan-frying (which seals the outside), braising in the sauce allows the meatball's juices to intermingle with the sauce, enriching both. Check internal temp: **75°C / 167°F**.
- 4 The egg — the theatrical moment:** Make wells in the sauce between the meatballs. Crack eggs directly into the wells. Cover and cook 4-5 minutes until the whites are set but the yolks are still runny. Bring the tagine directly to the table — this is a tableside moment. When the lid lifts, the guest sees the whole egg nestled in the red sauce with the meatballs, steam rising. The runny yolk breaks as the guest eats and enriches the sauce. Serve with warm bread for dipping — this is not a dish for cutlery alone.

Chef's Tip: This is your fastest main at a comfortable 15-minute fire time. Pre-batch the tomato sauce and keep warm; roll kefta to order (or batch-roll and refrigerate). Once the sauce is hot, this dish comes together in 15 minutes. The egg is the selling visual — describe it as "baked eggs in spiced meatball sauce, served in the tagine" and it sells itself every time.

EGGS

GLUTEN (bread side)

Bastilla au Poulet — Moroccan Chicken & Almond Pie

Layered warqa pie: chicken, almond, egg, cinnamon, icing sugar — sweet-savoury · Sell: \$27.99

8 min service (90min batch)

Main

Target FC: 24%

Signature

The Bastilla Story: Bastilla (also *bisteeya* or *pastilla*) is considered the crown jewel of Moroccan cuisine — the dish served at royal tables, at weddings, at celebrations. Its origin is the Moorish court of Andalusia, arriving in Morocco with Arab and Jewish refugees after the 1492 Reconquista. The original version uses pigeon (*hamam*) — the bird of palaces. In restaurants, chicken is the standard substitute. What makes bastilla philosophically Moroccan is its refusal of

the Western sweet-savoury binary: the savoury spiced chicken and egg filling is encased in paper-thin warqa pastry and dusted generously with icing sugar and cinnamon. This is not a mistake. It is the point. The Fez aristocracy considered this interplay of opposites the highest culinary achievement.

INGREDIENTS (PER 2-PERSON BASTILLA)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Chicken thighs (poached, shredded)	300g raw	\$2.13
Blanched almonds, toasted + ground	80g	\$1.77
Eggs (scrambled-set in broth)	3 x 55g	\$1.05
Phyllo / warqa dough sheets	100g (8-10 sheets)	\$0.89
Ras el hanout	5g	\$0.15
Cinnamon (filling + dust)	4g	\$0.03
Saffron (0.1g)	0.1g	\$2.80
Icing sugar (dust)	10g	\$0.02
Onion, grated + fresh parsley	60g + 10g	\$0.08
Orange flower water	10ml	\$0.16
Butter (clarified)	40g	\$0.40
Total cost (serves 2)		\$9.48

Cost per serve (half bastilla)	\$4.74
Sell price	\$27.99
Food cost %	16.9%
Contribution margin	\$23.25

METHOD

- 1 **The three-layer filling preparation:** Bastilla has three distinct filling components assembled in sequence. Layer 1 — Chicken: poach chicken thighs in spiced broth (onion, saffron, ras el hanout, ginger, cinnamon, parsley) until very tender — 45 minutes. Remove chicken, shred finely. Reduce the poaching broth to approximately 200ml of intensely flavoured liquid. Layer 2 — Egg: beat 3 eggs. Add to the simmering reduced broth and stir continuously until the eggs set into soft, scrambled curds infused with the saffron broth — not dry scrambled eggs, but loose, creamy, saffron-perfumed egg. Layer 3 — Almond: toast almonds until golden, grind to a coarse meal with cinnamon, sugar, and orange flower water.
- 2 **The warqa technique and layering:** Brush a 30cm round baking dish or skillet with clarified butter. Layer 4-5 sheets of phyllo, brushing each with butter and overlapping to extend beyond the dish edge (the overhang will fold over the filling). The multiple thin layers create the distinctive shattering-crispy exterior. Add the chicken filling, spreading evenly. Add the saffron egg on top of the chicken. Finally, add the almond-cinnamon layer on top of the egg. The order matters: chicken on the bottom (heaviest), egg in the middle (binding), almond on top (fragrant, slightly crumbly).
- 3 **Folding, sealing, and baking:** Fold the overhanging phyllo sheets up and over the filling to seal the top. Add 3-4 more buttered phyllo sheets on top, tucking the edges under. Press gently to compact. Brush the top generously with clarified butter. Bake at **375°F / 190°C** for 20-25 minutes until the top is deep golden and shatters when pressed with a spatula. The bastilla should feel rigid — not soft. A soft bastilla is undercooked and the pastry is not yet crispy. Allow to rest 5 minutes before inverting.
- 4 **The icing sugar moment:** Invert the bastilla onto a serving plate (crispy side up). Working quickly with a fine-mesh sieve, dust a generous, even layer of icing sugar over the entire surface. Then, using a thin line of cinnamon, draw a decorative geometric pattern — traditionally the star of Fez, or simple diagonal lines. The icing sugar will melt slightly on the hot pastry, creating a thin, lacquer-like sweet crust. Serve immediately — at the table, before the sugar soaks in. The moment of tableside dusting is a service event.

Chef's Tip: Bastilla is a batch item — make individual 2-person bastillas during morning prep and refrigerate unbaked. Bake to order (25 minutes) or par-bake 15 minutes, rest, and finish 8

minutes at service. Do not attempt to make bastilla to order from scratch — the assembly alone takes 20 minutes. The icing sugar must be applied at service — sugar applied before refrigeration dissolves and disappears.

GLUTEN (phyllo)

EGGS

TREE NUTS (almonds)

DAIRY (butter)

Couscous Royale — Lamb, Chicken, Merguez & Seven Vegetables

The great feast dish: three meats, seven vegetables, harissa broth on the side · Sell: \$31.99

8 min service (batch)

Main

Target FC: 28%

Friday-Sunday Special

The Couscous Technique — Three Steamings: Couscous (from the Berber *seksu*) is not rice and cannot be treated like rice. True Moroccan couscous is steamed three times over the braising broth in a *couscoussière* (a double pot where the base holds the stew and the perforated top holds the grain), with rubbing between each steam to separate the grains and allow even cooking. Most restaurants use the boil-in-water shortcut — the result is a sticky, clumped mass that bears no resemblance to the real thing. The authentic method produces individual grains that are light, separate, and saturated with the broth's flavour. The three-steam method takes 90 minutes total but produces a completely different product.

INGREDIENTS (PER PORTION)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Lamb shoulder piece, bone-in	150g	\$2.99
Chicken thigh, bone-in	140g (1 thigh)	\$0.99
Merguez sausage (1-2 links)	80g	\$1.42
Couscous, medium grain	120g dry	\$0.66
Turnip, carrot, zucchini, pumpkin	60g each	\$0.44
Chickpeas (cooked)	60g	\$0.07
Cabbage + onion	40g each	\$0.07
Ras el hanout for broth	6g	\$0.18
Saffron (0.1g)	0.1g	\$2.80
Harissa (side, 30ml)	30g	\$0.53
Butter (finish couscous)	20g	\$0.20
Total cost per serve		\$10.35

Cost per serve	\$10.35
Sell price	\$31.99
Food cost %	32.4%
Contribution margin	\$21.64

△ FC at 32.4% exceeds target due to three-protein build. Offset with high-margin drinks. Position as weekend special for max table spend.

METHOD

- The broth foundation:** Build a deeply flavoured broth in a large pot: brown lamb and chicken in batches, remove. Sweat grated onion in the fat, add ras el hanout, cinnamon, ginger, turmeric, saffron. Add lamb and chicken back with enough water to cover. Simmer 1.5 hours. The vegetables are added in stages based on their cooking times: dense root vegetables (turnip, carrot, parsnip) go in after 1 hour; softer vegetables (zucchini, pumpkin, cabbage) in the last 20 minutes. Chickpeas (pre-cooked from dried) go in the last 10 minutes to heat through without disintegrating.
- The three-steam couscous method:** First steam: toss dry couscous with cold water (1:1), rub between palms to separate grains, rest 5 minutes until water is absorbed. Steam over the simmering broth for 20 minutes in a cheesecloth-lined colander. Remove, tip into a bowl, rub with cold water and a tablespoon of oil to separate grains. Second steam: 20 more minutes over broth.

Third steam: 15 minutes, finishing with butter rubbed in to give a rich, glossy sheen. Each steaming hydrates and cooks the grain more completely; each rubbing ensures no clumping.

3 Grill the merguez separately: Merguez sausage (spiced lamb and harissa, the sausage of North Africa) is not braised — it is grilled to order. Braised merguez becomes grey and loses its casing snap. Grill 4–5 minutes on a hot griddle or skillet until the casing is charred in spots and the interior is cooked through. The grilled sausage provides a char-spiced contrast to the gentle braised lamb and chicken.

4 The presentation — the mountain: Traditional couscous royale is presented as a mountain. Mound the couscous in the centre of a large bowl. Arrange the lamb, chicken, and vegetables around and partially on the couscous. Place the grilled merguez on top. Ladle a cup of the cooking broth over the mountain at the table. Serve the harissa separately in a small bowl, to be added by the guest according to their preference. The broth is poured at the table — the steam and the sound are part of the experience.

Chef's Tip: Batch the broth and meats in large quantities on Friday morning for the weekend service when couscous royale is your feature special. The couscous itself needs to be steamed in batches and held warm, covered, in a bain-marie. Never hold couscous in an uncovered container — it dries and hardens within 15 minutes of service. A damp towel over the bowl in the bain-marie keeps it perfect for 90 minutes.

GLUTEN (couscous contains semolina)

DAIRY (butter)

Chermoula Grilled Prawns

16/20 prawns, chermoula marinade, saffron aioli, grilled lemon · Sell: \$27.99

10 min to order

Main

Target FC: 24%

INGREDIENTS (PER PORTION — 6 PRAWNS)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Prawns 16/20, shell-on	6 prawns (~200g)	\$3.97
Chermoula marinade (batch)	40g	\$0.48
Fresh coriander	8g	\$0.07
Cumin, paprika, cayenne (chermoula)	4g total	\$0.06
Preserved lemon (chermoula)	10g	\$0.14
Garlic (chermoula)	6g	\$0.03
Olive oil (chermoula)	20ml	\$0.16
Saffron aioli (batch — 30ml)	30g	\$0.68
Lemon halves for grilling	1 lemon	\$0.10
Couscous or flatbread side	80g/1 piece	\$0.28
Total cost per serve		\$5.97

Cost per serve	\$5.97
Sell price	\$27.99
Food cost %	21.3%
Contribution margin	\$22.02

METHOD

1 Chermoula — the universal Moroccan marinade: Chermoula is Morocco's answer to chimichurri — a herb-spice-acid marinade used for fish, seafood, and occasionally chicken. Blend: fresh coriander, flat-leaf parsley, garlic, cumin, smoked paprika, cayenne, preserved lemon rind, lemon juice, and olive oil. The texture should be a loose paste, not a smooth purée. Chermoula is used in two ways: as a raw marinade (applied to the protein before cooking) and as a finishing sauce (a fresh batch kept separate, served alongside). The cooked marinade chars and caramelises; the fresh sauce brightens and lifts.

2 Butterfly and marinate: Butterfly the prawns through the shell on the back — cut along the

curve with scissors or a knife, opening the prawn while keeping it in the shell. This technique creates maximum surface area for marinade penetration and ensures the prawn cooks evenly on the grill. Shell-on grilling protects the prawn flesh from the intense direct heat and adds a slight smoky flavour as the shell chars. Marinate 30 minutes minimum — not more than 2 hours, as the acid in the lemon and preserved lemon will begin to denature the protein.

3 High-heat grill: Grill on the highest heat available — the shell should char within 2 minutes per side. Total cook time: 4–5 minutes for 16/20 prawns. Overcooked prawns turn rubbery and chalky — the internal temperature should reach **63°C / 145°F** and no higher. The shell acts as a heat buffer — pull the prawns when the flesh is just turning opaque throughout. They continue cooking off the heat. Place halved lemons cut-side down on the grill alongside — charred lemon has less acidity and more Maillard sweetness than raw lemon.

4 Saffron aioli: Blend saffron-bloomed in warm water into a base aioli (egg yolk, garlic, olive oil, lemon). The saffron turns the aioli a vivid gold colour and adds its characteristic floral-medicinal flavour note. Make in batches. The aioli should be thick enough to hold its shape on the plate. Plate: prawns arranged shell-side down, charred lemon alongside, fresh chermoula drizzled over, saffron aioli in a small ramekin, scattered fresh coriander.

Chef's Tip: Chermoula can be made in bulk and refrigerated for 5 days or frozen for 3 months. Always keep two batches: one for marinating (which gets discarded with the raw prawn shells) and one fresh batch for finishing at service. Never use the raw-protein marinade as a serving sauce — it contains raw shellfish juices.

SHELLFISH

EGGS (aioli)

Mechoui — Slow-Roasted Lamb Shoulder

Whole-roasted lamb shoulder, cumin-salt dip, warm flatbread · Sell: \$34.99

5 min service (6hr oven)

Main

Target FC: 28%

Weekend Only

INGREDIENTS (PER PORTION — 1 SHOULDER SERVES 4)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Lamb shoulder, bone-in (whole)	400g portion of 1kg shoulder	\$7.94
Clarified butter (smen)	30g	\$0.30
Ras el hanout	6g	\$0.18
Cumin + coriander, ground	3g each	\$0.04
Garlic, slivered (inserted into meat)	10g	\$0.05
Cumin-salt dip (toasted cumin + fleur de sel)	5g	\$0.06
Fresh khobz / flatbread	1 large portion	\$0.30
Fresh coriander and lemon	—	\$0.08
Total cost per serve		\$8.95

Cost per serve	\$8.95
Sell price	\$34.99
Food cost %	25.6%
Contribution margin	\$26.04

METHOD

1 The mechoui tradition — patience as technique: Mechoui (*from the Arabic for "grilled"*) is traditionally a whole lamb slow-roasted in an earthen pit over embers — the Moroccan version of a pit barbecue. In a restaurant context, a bone-in lamb shoulder achieves an equivalent result in a low oven. The key is the combination of time, low temperature, and fat. Make deep slits all over the lamb with a knife. Insert slivers of garlic into the slits. Mix soft butter (or *smen* — aged clarified butter) with ras el hanout, cumin, and salt into a paste. Rub the paste all over and into the slits. The fat carries the spice compounds deep into the meat during the long cook.

2 The low-slow cook: Place the lamb in a roasting pan with a small amount of water in the base.

Cover tightly with foil. Cook at **275°F / 135°C** for 5 hours. The collagen in the shoulder (this cut has abundant connective tissue) requires a minimum of 4 hours at this temperature to convert to gelatin. Collagen → gelatin conversion is irreversible and is what makes slow-cooked lamb silky, self-basting, and able to be pulled apart with fingers. At 3 hours, the lamb is cooked but not yet falling-off-the-bone. At 5 hours, the meat pulls in sheets from the bone.

3 The final blast: Remove foil for the last 30 minutes and increase to **425°F / 220°C**. This crisps the exterior and caramelises the butter-spice crust. The contrast of a crackling, spiced exterior and the yielding, falling meat within is the defining sensory experience of mechoui. Internal temperature target: **82°C / 180°F** — well above typical lamb service temperature, because at this point the collagen has converted and the meat is in a different category entirely.

4 The cumin-salt ritual: Mechoui is traditionally eaten standing around the whole roast, with guests using their right hand to tear pieces of meat and dip them in cumin and salt. In a restaurant, portion the shoulder at the pass but serve with a small bowl of toasted ground cumin mixed with fleur de sel. The ritual of dipping and eating hand-to-mouth is part of the dish — mention it to the guest: "Traditionally this is eaten with your hands — the cumin salt is the condiment."

Chef's Tip: One whole 2kg shoulder starts at 7am and is ready by 1pm — plan your lunch service accordingly. A shoulder yields approximately 4 good portions. Pre-sell mechoui when guests are seated: "Today we have mechoui — whole roasted lamb shoulder, been in the oven since 7am. \$34.99. Only 4 portions." Scarcity and specificity sell this dish.

DAIRY (butter/smen) GLUTEN (flatbread side)

Rfissa — Shredded Chicken on Msemen with Fenugreek Broth

Shredded chicken, lentils, fenugreek broth, torn msemen flatbread · Sell: \$23.99

8 min service (batch) Main Target FC: 21%

INGREDIENTS (PER PORTION)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Chicken thighs, braised + shredded	200g raw	\$1.41
Green lentils, cooked	80g dry	\$0.09
Msemen flatbread (torn pieces)	2 pieces	\$0.38
Fenugreek seeds (ground)	3g	\$0.03
Ras el hanout	4g	\$0.12
Saffron (0.08g)	0.08g	\$2.24
Onion, grated	50g	\$0.05
Chicken broth	200ml	\$0.10
Olive oil + fresh coriander	15ml + 8g	\$0.18
Total cost per serve		\$4.60

Cost per serve	\$4.60
Sell price	\$23.99
Food cost %	19.2%
Contribution margin	\$19.39

METHOD

1 The rfissa story — a celebration dish: Rfissa is traditionally prepared for new mothers after childbirth — fenugreek is believed to stimulate milk production and restore strength. It is also a celebration dish served at Eid and at family gatherings. This cultural context is part of the story — tell guests. The dish is unusual: it is deconstructed bread-soup-stew in one bowl, where torn msemen flatbread soaks in a fragrant fenugreek-saffron broth and is topped with braised chicken and lentils. It is deeply comforting — Morocco's answer to pho or ramen in terms of cultural healing power.

- 2 **The fenugreek broth:** Fenugreek seeds have a distinctive bittersweet, slightly maple-like flavour (the compound sotolone is responsible — the same compound found in maple syrup). Toast seeds lightly, grind, and add to the chicken braising broth with onion, saffron, ras el hanout, and a cinnamon stick. Braise chicken thighs in this spiced broth 45–60 minutes until falling-off-the-bone tender. Shred. The broth should taste complex, slightly bitter from the fenugreek, fragrant from saffron. Add cooked lentils to the broth — they thicken it slightly.
- 3 **The msemen base:** Tear fresh msemen into rough pieces (3–4cm) and arrange in the base of the serving bowl. The torn, irregular pieces are intentional — they absorb broth at different rates, creating a textural gradient from crispy at the top to soft and broth-soaked at the base. Pre-made msemen from morning prep works perfectly. Never use day-old msemen that has been refrigerated — refrigeration makes it hard and dense.
- 4 **Assemble and serve:** Arrange shredded chicken over the msemen. Add a scoop of lentils. Ladle the hot fenugreek broth over everything — generously — the msemen needs enough broth to soften and absorb. Drizzle with olive oil. Scatter fresh coriander. Serve immediately. This dish cannot hold — the msemen will continue softening and eventually dissolve. Fire and serve within 2 minutes of assembly.

Chef's Tip: Rfissa is your most culturally distinctive dish and the one that sophisticated Moroccan food guests will recognise and order immediately. It is essentially unknown to non-Moroccan guests — a selling opportunity. Describe it as: "Our celebration dish — chicken and lentils in a saffron-fenugreek broth, served over our house-made flatbread. This is what Moroccan mothers are traditionally served after childbirth." That detail is memorable and tells a true story.

GLUTEN (msemen)

DAIRY (msemen contains butter)

Lamb Mrouzia — Honey, Raisin & Ras el Hanout Tagine

Slow-braised lamb ribs, honey glaze, golden raisins, ras el hanout · Sell: \$27.99

5 min service (3hr batch)

Main

Target FC: 26%

INGREDIENTS (PER PORTION)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Lamb ribs / shoulder, bone-in	300g raw	\$5.97
Ras el hanout (generous)	8g	\$0.24
Honey	30g	\$0.53
Golden raisins	40g	\$0.24
Blanched almonds	25g	\$0.55
Cinnamon sticks (2)	2 sticks	\$0.05
Ground ginger + black pepper	3g each	\$0.04
Onion, grated	60g	\$0.06
Butter + olive oil	15g + 15ml	\$0.27
Couscous (side)	80g dry	\$0.44
Total cost per serve		\$8.39

Cost per serve	\$8.39
Sell price	\$27.99
Food cost %	30.0%
Contribution margin	\$19.60

METHOD

- 1 **The mrouzia heritage — Andalusian medieval cuisine:** Mrouzia is one of the oldest preserved Moroccan recipes, found in the 13th-century Andalusian cookbook *Manuscrito Anónimo*. It is a dish of lamb braised in honey and spices — a medieval court dish that reveals the Arab culinary tradition of *agridulce* (sweet-sour), the philosophical ancestor of Moroccan sweet-savoury cooking. The ras el hanout in mrouzia should be the most complex, most aromatic blend you have

— this is the dish where spice complexity is not background but foreground. Brown the lamb in a mixture of butter and olive oil — the milk solids in the butter brown and contribute a nutty depth.

2 The spice wall: After browning, add grated onion, ras el hanout (use double the quantity you think is appropriate — mrouzia is a bold dish), ground ginger, cinnamon sticks, black pepper, and saffron. The spice quantity in mrouzia is not a seasoning — it is the structural flavour of the dish. Add just enough water to barely cover. Bring to a simmer, cover, and cook on the lowest possible heat for 2.5 hours. The lamb should be yielding and collapsing but not completely falling off the bone — it needs to hold its shape for service.

3 The honey glaze — the reduction stage: After 2.5 hours, the lamb is cooked. Add honey and golden raisins. Cook uncovered for 30–40 minutes, stirring occasionally, while the liquid reduces to a thick, dark, glossy glaze that coats every piece of meat and every raisin. This reduction stage is where the dish transforms from a braise into mrouzia — the honey caramelises (above 160°F/71°C the natural sugars in honey undergo the same caramelisation reactions as table sugar), the sauce thickens, and the entire dish darkens in colour and deepens in flavour.

4 Finish with almonds and serve: Fry whole blanched almonds in butter until golden. Scatter over the finished mrouzia at service. The crunchy almond against the glossy, sticky, raisin-jewelled lamb is textural and visual. Plate in a shallow bowl with couscous alongside. The sauce should be thick enough to hold its place on the plate — not running. If too thin, reduce further. A good mrouzia sauce looks like dark honey poured over the lamb.

Chef's Tip: Mrouzia is traditionally made for Eid al-Adha using the sacrificial lamb — it is one of the dishes that Moroccan families associate most strongly with celebration and family. Guests who are Moroccan will recognise it immediately and order it on sight. Non-Moroccan guests need one sentence: "Medieval Moroccan lamb in a honey-raisin glaze with ras el hanout — it is one of the oldest recipes in North African cooking."

TREE NUTS (almonds)

DAIRY (butter)

Vegetarian Tagine — Root Vegetable, Chickpea & Preserved Lemon

Sweet potato, carrot, turnip, chickpea, preserved lemon, saffron broth · Sell: \$19.99

5 min service (batch)

Main

Target FC: 15%

Vegan ✓

INGREDIENTS (PER PORTION)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Sweet potato, cubed	100g	\$0.14
Carrot + turnip, chunked	80g each	\$0.14
Zucchini + red pepper	70g each	\$0.20
Chickpeas, cooked from dried	80g	\$0.09
Preserved lemon (1/4 lemon)	30g	\$0.40
Ras el hanout	4g	\$0.12
Saffron (0.08g)	0.08g	\$2.24
Crushed tomatoes	60g	\$0.06
Onion, grated	50g	\$0.05
Olive oil + coriander	20ml + 8g	\$0.22
Couscous (side)	80g dry	\$0.44
Total cost per serve		\$4.10

Cost per serve	\$4.10
Sell price	\$19.99
Food cost %	20.5%
Contribution margin	\$15.89

METHOD

- 1

Vegetable staging — texture management: The key failure in vegetable tagines is uniform mushiness from adding all vegetables simultaneously. Stage the additions: start with the densest vegetables first (turnip, carrot — 40 minutes), then sweet potato (30 minutes), then zucchini and pepper (20 minutes). Chickpeas (pre-cooked) enter in the last 10 minutes. Each vegetable should retain its individual texture and colour — a well-cooked vegetarian tagine has distinct pieces with a sauce that has absorbed the flavour of everything.
- 2

Build the base without meat: Sweat grated onion in good olive oil. Add ras el hanout, saffron (bloomed), cumin, and cinnamon. The absence of meat means the spice base must carry more weight — use 30% more ras el hanout than in a meat tagine. Add crushed tomatoes and cook down 8 minutes. The tomato creates both acidity and body. Add the vegetable stock — homemade is ideal; the liquid needs to taste of something since there is no meat collagen to enrich it.
- 3

Preserved lemon integration: Add preserved lemon at the start of cooking (unlike in a meat tagine where timing varies). Vegetables benefit from the longer integration — the lemon's fermented salinity permeates the broth more thoroughly. Moroccan preserved lemons are made by packing whole lemons in salt and their own juice, fermented for a minimum of 4 weeks. The salt draws out liquid through osmosis; the lactobacillus bacteria convert sugars to lactic acid; the essential oils concentrate as water leaves the peel. The result is a preserved peel with a complex, salty-fermented-citrus flavour impossible to shortcut.
- 4

Finish and serve: Check seasoning — the broth should taste complex and bold. The saffron should be perceptible. The preserved lemon should be present but not dominant. Adjust with lemon juice if needed. Finish with a generous handful of fresh coriander. Serve in the clay tagine pot with couscous alongside. Drizzle extra-virgin olive oil over the top at service — it adds richness that the absence of animal fat leaves behind and makes the vegetables glisten. This is your vegan offering — do not present it as a lesser option. Present it as the most ancient tradition in Moroccan cooking.

Chef's Tip: This dish has the lowest food cost (20.5%) and the highest flexibility — any seasonal vegetable works within the tagine framework. Use it to absorb vegetable trim from other dishes: leftover pumpkin from the couscous royale prep, carrot trim, etc. Keep the spice levels generous — under-spiced vegetarian food is the most common failure in this category.

NONE (vegan, gluten-free if couscous omitted and served with rice)

3 Desserts

Chebakia — Honey & Sesame Fried Pastry

Flower-shaped fried dough, hot honey bath, sesame, rose water · Sell: \$9.99

3 min service Dessert Target FC: 14% Batch

INGREDIENTS (4 PIECES PER SERVE / BATCH ÷ 24)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Plain flour	40g portion	\$0.03
Sesame seeds (in dough)	8g	\$0.06
Anise seeds, ground	1g	\$0.01
Orange flower water	5ml	\$0.08
Cinnamon + turmeric	1g each	\$0.01
Honey (for bath + finish)	25g	\$0.44
Rose water	3ml	\$0.04
Sesame seeds (for finish)	5g	\$0.04
Frying oil	—	\$0.10
Total cost per serve (4 pcs)		\$0.81

Cost per serve \$0.81

Sell price	\$9.99
Food cost %	8.1%
Contribution margin	\$9.18

METHOD

- 1

The dough — a sesame pastry: Mix flour, ground sesame, anise seeds, cinnamon, turmeric, and a pinch of salt. Add warm water, vegetable oil, and orange flower water gradually until a smooth, pliable, non-sticky dough forms. Rest 30 minutes — the gluten relaxes and the dough becomes easier to roll thinly. The sesame seeds integrated into the dough (not just the topping) create a nutty crunch throughout the pastry — chebakia is as textural as much as a flavour experience.
- 2

Shaping — the flower form: Roll dough to 3mm thickness. Cut strips or use the traditional 5-cut shaping method: make 5 parallel cuts in a rectangle of dough, leaving the ends intact, then weave the strips and press together to form the characteristic flower or rosette shape. The intricate shape is functional — the folds and open spaces create maximum surface area for honey absorption. A simple piece of fried dough would not absorb honey the same way; the complexity of the shape is the genius of the design.
- 3

Fry and honey bath: Fry shaped chebakia at **170°C / 338°F** (slightly lower than other frying — the honey in the dough can cause burning at higher temperatures) for 4–5 minutes, turning, until deep golden. The moment they emerge from the fryer, plunge directly into simmering honey (warmed with rose water in a wide pan) for 1–2 minutes. The hot fried pastry, still open-pored from frying, absorbs the warm honey deeply. This is not a drizzle — it is a bath. Remove with tongs, allow excess honey to drip.
- 4

Sesame and rose water finish: While still warm and honey-sticky, scatter toasted sesame seeds generously over the chebakia. A final spray or drop of rose water adds a floral top note. Chebakia can be made in large batches, keeps for 5 days at room temperature (the honey acts as a preservative), and needs only seconds of presentation at service — plate 4 pieces, scatter extra sesame, done. This is your best dessert margin at 8.1% food cost.

Chef's Tip: Chebakia is the taste of Ramadan in Morocco — every family makes kilos of them during the holy month to break the fast with harira. Explain this context to guests: "These are Morocco's Ramadan pastry — fried, honey-soaked, sesame and rose water. We make them every day; during Ramadan they'd be eaten after sunset to break the fast." The cultural story is the pre-sell.

GLUTEN (wheat) SESAME

Kaab el Ghazal — Gazelle Horn Almond Pastries

Crescent almond-marzipan pastry, orange flower water · Sell: \$9.99 (3 pieces)

2 min service Dessert Target FC: 15% Batch

INGREDIENTS (3 PIECES PER SERVE / BATCH ÷ 20)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Plain flour (dough)	35g portion	\$0.03
Butter (dough)	8g	\$0.08
Orange flower water (dough)	5ml	\$0.08
Blanched almonds (ground for filling)	30g	\$0.66
Icing sugar (filling)	15g	\$0.03
Cinnamon + mastic gum (filling)	1g + 0.5g	\$0.03
Orange flower water (filling)	5ml	\$0.08
Icing sugar (finish dusting)	5g	\$0.01
Total cost per serve (3 pcs)		\$1.00

Cost per serve	\$1.00
Sell price	\$9.99

Food cost %	10.0%
Contribution margin	\$8.99

METHOD

- 1 **The almond filling — Moroccan marzipan:** Ground blanched almonds + icing sugar + cinnamon + a drop of mastic gum resin (optional but traditional — it adds a subtle piney, resinous note used in Moroccan and Levantine pastry) + orange flower water. Mix to a paste that holds its shape when rolled but is not stiff. The filling is essentially marzipan, Moroccan-style — without the artificial almond extract that characterises commercial marzipan. The orange flower water is the flavour signature.
- 2 **The pastry dough:** Mix flour, melted butter, orange flower water, and just enough water to bring together a smooth, pliable dough. Knead 5 minutes. This is a short pastry — not rich with butter like a French pâte brisée, but lean and tender. Roll very thin (2mm) — the pastry should be almost translucent over the almond filling when the crescent is shaped. Thin pastry allows the filling's aroma to permeate.
- 3 **Shape the gazelle horn:** Roll the almond filling into a log approximately 8cm long, curved slightly. Place on the thin pastry sheet, fold pastry over, and press to seal. Trim with a pastry cutter to create a clean crescent edge. The crescent shape imitates a gazelle horn — the name references the elegant curve and the delicacy of the pastry. The seal must be tight — if the almond filling escapes during baking, it burns and creates bitter spots.
- 4 **Bake and finish:** Bake at **350°F / 175°C** for 12–15 minutes until barely golden — kaab el ghazal should be pale to very light gold, not brown. The pastry is delicate; overbaking dries out the almond filling and makes the pastry hard. Cool completely. Dust generously with icing sugar. These keep perfectly at room temperature for 5 days in an airtight container. Serve 3 pieces per dessert portion alongside the mint tea — they are the classic tea accompaniment.

Chef's Tip: Offer kaab el ghazal as a complimentary petit four with the mint tea ceremony — a single piece per guest. The cost is \$0.33, but the impression is disproportionate. A guest who receives something unexpected and beautiful free of charge remembers the restaurant differently. It is the most efficient hospitality gesture on your menu.

GLUTEN (wheat) TREE NUTS (almonds) DAIRY (butter)

Orange & Cinnamon Salad

Chilled navel oranges, cinnamon, orange flower water, fresh mint · Sell: \$7.99

3 min service Dessert Target FC: 11% Batch

INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Navel oranges (3 medium, segmented)	2 large oranges	\$0.50
Ground cinnamon	1.5g	\$0.01
Orange flower water	5ml	\$0.08
Honey (light drizzle)	8g	\$0.14
Fresh mint, chiffonade	4g	\$0.04
Pomegranate seeds (garnish)	10g	\$0.10
Total cost per serve		\$0.87

Cost per serve	\$0.87
Sell price	\$7.99
Food cost %	10.9%
Contribution margin	\$7.12

METHOD

- 1 **Slice cleanly and cold:** Peel oranges with a knife, removing all pith. Slice into 5mm rounds or

segment. Arrange on a chilled plate. This dessert requires excellent oranges — it has nowhere to hide. Navel oranges at peak season (December–April in the US) are the best choice. Mandarin, blood orange in season, or a mixture adds colour and variety. Refrigerate the plates until service — this dish should be cold, almost bracing, as a palate cleanser after a rich tagine or bastilla.

2 The cinnamon principle: Morocco uses cinnamon on both sweet and savoury applications more than almost any other cuisine. The combination of orange and cinnamon seems almost French (think duck à l'orange) but in Morocco it predates French influence by centuries. Dust cinnamon lightly from height — an even veil over the entire plate, not a blob in the centre. The visual should be a pale orange plate with a warm brown dusting. Too much cinnamon makes the dish taste medicinal.

3 Orange flower water and honey: Drizzle a few drops of orange flower water over the oranges — it amplifies the citrus while adding the floral-water note that makes this unmistakably Moroccan. A light drizzle of liquid honey catches the light and adds a gentle sweetness. The dessert should be primarily the fresh orange — the honey and flower water are seasoning, not sauce.

4 Mint and pomegranate finish: Scatter fresh mint chiffonade and pomegranate seeds over the top at service. The pomegranate seeds (ruby red against the orange) create a visual that photographs beautifully and suggests the spice market. Serve immediately — cut orange deteriorates quickly as the segments dry and the juice pools. This dessert must go from plating to table in under 2 minutes.

Chef's Tip: This is your palate-cleanser dessert — position it as "light" and "refreshing" after a heavy tagine or couscous. It is also the most frequently chosen dessert by guests who claim they don't want dessert. At \$7.99 with a \$7.12 contribution margin and 2 minutes of prep time, it is the most efficient item on your dessert menu. Keep a batch of pre-segmented oranges in the fridge at all times.

NONE (vegan, gluten-free)

Seffa — Sweet Couscous with Raisins & Almonds

Steamed sweet couscous, butter, raisins, almonds, cinnamon, icing sugar · Sell: \$9.99

4 min service

Dessert

Target FC: 17%

Batch

INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Couscous, fine grain	80g dry	\$0.44
Unsalted butter	20g	\$0.20
Golden raisins	25g	\$0.15
Blanched almonds, toasted + halved	20g	\$0.44
Ground cinnamon	2g	\$0.02
Icing sugar (generous)	15g	\$0.03
Orange flower water	5ml	\$0.08
Warm milk (for steaming / serving)	60ml	\$0.06
Total cost per serve		\$1.42

Cost per serve	\$1.42
Sell price	\$9.99
Food cost %	14.2%
Contribution margin	\$8.57

METHOD

1 Sweet couscous steaming: Seffa uses fine-grain couscous rather than the medium grain used in savoury couscous dishes. Prepare by the steam method (as described in Couscous Royale) but use warm milk or water rather than broth. The light, fluffy, butter-finished couscous is the canvas

for the sweet toppings. The grain must be perfectly separate — seffa with clumped couscous is unacceptable. Work the butter in with your fingertips while the couscous is still hot, ensuring every grain is coated. The butter provides richness and a silky mouthfeel.

2 Plum the raisins: Plump golden raisins in warm orange flower water for 20 minutes before incorporating. Dry raisins in seffa are chewy and detract from the light texture. Plumped raisins are juicy, fragrant, and integrate smoothly into the dessert. The orange flower water also perfumes the raisins from the inside. Drain but do not rinse — the orange flower water should cling to the raisin surface.

3 Toasted almond preparation: Toast blanched almonds until genuinely golden (not pale) and halve lengthwise. The visual of a halved almond — showing the pale interior against the golden exterior — is more elegant than a whole almond. Alternatively, use slivered almonds for a more refined presentation. Scatter while still warm over the plated seffa so they retain their crunch against the soft couscous.

4 The presentation mound and finishing: Mound the buttered couscous in the centre of the bowl. Arrange raisins and almonds in a decorative pattern — traditionally concentric rings or a spiral, creating a miniature version of the couscous royale mountain. Using a fine-mesh sieve, dust generously with icing sugar and cinnamon from directly above — the dessert should look snow-dusted. Serve with warm milk on the side (traditional — poured over the seffa by the guest), or a small pot of warm honey.

Chef's Tip: Seffa can be made in batches and portioned into individual serving dishes, kept warm in a bain-marie for service. It holds well for 60–90 minutes if covered. The decorative topping (almonds, raisins, icing sugar) is added at service. This is your quickest dessert — meaningful when the table has been waiting. Describe it as "warm sweet couscous — Morocco's answer to rice pudding, but lighter."

GLUTEN (semolina couscous)

DAIRY (butter, warm milk)

TREE NUTS (almonds)

4 Drinks Menu

Moroccan Mint Tea — Atay

\$6.99 (3 glasses)

Gunpowder green tea, fresh spearmint, sugar — served in 3 small glasses by tradition. The first glass is said to be as gentle as life, the second as strong as love, the third as bitter as death. Poured from height to create foam (*raga*) — the height is not theatrical; the foam signals freshness and skill. To refuse is culturally significant: it says something has gone wrong.

Cost	\$0.56
Food cost %	8.0%

Jus d'Avocat — Avocado Juice

\$8.99

Blended ripe avocado, cold milk, sugar, and a drop of orange flower water. Morocco's most beloved café drink — thick, creamy, naturally sweet, and uniquely filling. Nothing like an avocado smoothie in the US context. This is a meal supplement, a dessert substitute, and a cultural statement. Serve with a drizzle of honey on top. Best social media drink on the menu.

Cost	\$1.44
Food cost %	16.0%

Rose Water Lemonade

\$6.99

Freshly squeezed lemon juice, sugar syrup, sparkling water, a dash of rose water, and dried rose petals floating on top. Pale pink, fragrant, visually beautiful. The rose water must be used sparingly — it is intensely perfumed and a heavy hand makes the drink taste like soap. A light hand creates a floral, lemon-forward drink that feels like drinking a Marrakech garden.

Cost	\$0.62
Food cost %	8.9%

Iced Moroccan Coffee

\$6.99

Strong espresso or cold brew, spiced with ground cardamom and a pinch of cinnamon, served over ice with warm frothy milk on the side. Moroccan café culture (*café cassé* or broken coffee — half espresso, half milk) is as important to daily life as mint tea. The cardamom lifts and perfumes the coffee in a way that mirrors Gulf Arab coffee culture, reflecting Morocco's complex position at the crossroads of Berber, Arab, and Andalusian traditions.

Cost	\$0.80
Food cost %	11.4%

Casablanca Beer

\$8.99

Morocco's flagship lager, brewed since 1919 in Casablanca. Light, crisp, slightly malty — the ideal companion to spiced tagines and harissa-spiked dishes. Serve ice-cold in the bottle with a frosted glass. Casablanca Beer on the table is a cultural signal — guests who know Morocco will order it by name, and those who don't will ask about it. Both outcomes are good.

Cost	\$2.20
Food cost %	24.5%

Sidi Ali Mineral Water

\$4.99

Morocco's iconic mineral water, sourced from the Middle Atlas mountains. Still or sparkling. The label is recognisable to every Moroccan guest and signals authentic sourcing. For non-Moroccan guests, it is simply premium mineral water with a story. The name Sidi Ali means "Master Ali" — a saint whose spring supposedly fed the source. Serve in the bottle, opened at the table.

Cost	\$0.90
Food cost %	18.0%

Almond Milkshake — Lben Louz

\$7.99

Blended blanched almonds, cold whole milk, sugar, and orange flower water — the Moroccan almond shake. Thick, fragrant, slightly grainy in a way that signals real almonds (not syrup). Morocco is one of the world's largest almond producers and almond drinks appear on every café menu from Fez to Agadir. Drizzle honey on top, scatter three almond slices as garnish. Natural, filling, and genuinely delicious.

Cost	\$1.20
Food cost %	15.0%

Fresh Pomegranate Juice

\$7.99

Freshly pressed pomegranate juice, served chilled with a few seeds floating in the glass. Vivid ruby-red, tart, slightly tannic, antioxidant-rich. Morocco's Sefrou pomegranate festival is one of the oldest continuous agricultural celebrations in the country — the fruit is deeply embedded in Moroccan cultural identity. Serve in a clear glass to show the colour. The visual alone sells it.

Cost		\$1.44	
Food cost %		18.0%	

5

Kitchen Prep Flow — 7:00am to 3:00pm

The Moroccan Kitchen Principle: Moroccan cooking is organised around time. Tagines require 2-3 hours minimum. Bastilla assembly takes 90 minutes. Couscous steams in three 20-minute rounds. The morning prep is not prep — it is cooking. By service at 11am, the tagines must be done, the bastillas par-baked, the couscous steamed and holding, the briouats shaped and refrigerated. The afternoon kitchen refires and plates from batches created in the morning. This is fundamentally different from an à la minute kitchen — it requires precise morning sequencing.

	Head Chef	Line Cook	Steward
07:00-07:30	Temp check all cold storage 1-4°C . Season and brown lamb shoulder and lamb tagine bases. Start tagine braises — these need 2.5 hours minimum and must be in the pot by 7:30am to be service-ready by 10:00am. Check saffron stock — critical ingredient, never run out. Start preserved lemon check — quarter lemons for tagines.	Set up mise en place. Soak chickpeas overnight (for lunch) or open canned reserve. Begin kefta mince mix for cigares — roll and refrigerate. Set up phyllo station: cover sheets with damp cloth. Begin bastilla filling prep: poach chicken thighs in spiced broth (45 min).	Sanitise all surfaces. Prepare mint tea station: wash and dry fresh mint bunches, prepare gunpowder tea batch in holding. Brew first mint tea test batch — taste for sweetness and intensity. Prepare honey-bath for chebakia (warm). Prepare rose water lemonade syrup base. Check ice supply.
07:30-09:00	Start chicken tagine braises (90 min). Prepare chermoula batch for prawns — keep two separate bowls (marinating and serving). Begin beef kefta tagine tomato sauce batch. Check mrouzia status if on menu — honey glaze reduction requires attention. Taste all tagine broths — season now, not at service.	Assemble bastillas: three-layer filling, phyllo wrapping, press into individual baking dishes. Refrigerate unbaked. This is the critical 90-minute task — bastilla must be ready to bake by 9:30am for par-bake before lunch service. Shape briouats (triangle fold technique) — 24 pieces minimum. Refrigerate.	Prepare zaalouk and carrot salad batches — these improve overnight but must be ready for 11am service. Char and peel eggplants for zaalouk. Roast carrots for carrot salad. Prepare harissa dipping sauce batch (thin with olive oil and lemon). Prepare saffron aioli batch for prawns. Check all herb stocks — wash and spin dry coriander and parsley.
09:00-11:00 Prep continues	Par-bake bastillas 15 min at 375°F. Cool. Refrigerate. Check all tagine status — lamb should be falling tender by 10:30am. Adjust seasoning. Prepare couscous batch: first steam (20 min), rub, second steam (20 min), rub, hold in covered bain-marie. Prepare msemen dough — laminate, shape, refrigerate uncooked for griddle-to-order service.	Roll kefta meatballs for tagine (walnut size, 25g each). Batch tomato-harissa sauce. Butterfly and marinate prawns in chermoula. Steam seffa couscous (sweet, separate batch from savoury). Prepare almond filling for kaab el ghazal — batch-bake remaining pastries. Prepare orange and cinnamon salad components: segment oranges, keep cold.	Prepare juice station: press pomegranate juice batch, prepare avocado juice base mix. Portion all sauces and condiments. Prepare table condiment trays: harissa, olive oil, preserved lemon wedges, cumin-salt mix. Write service board: today's mechoui availability (if applicable), couscous royale (weekend). Confirm front-of-house on today's specials and 86s.
11:00-14:30 Lunch Service	Run the pass. Fire tagines: 5 min reheat in clay pot with ladle of broth in 350°F oven. Fire bastilla: 8-minute finish bake, then icing sugar at pass. All tagines served in their clay pots — visual standards non-negotiable. Monitor	Griddle msemen to order (3-4 min per side). Grill prawns and merguez to order (5 min). Assemble rfiassa: warm broth, tear msemen, shred chicken, ladle at pass. Plate couscous royale: mountain build, arrange meats, ladle	Full service speed. Mint tea ceremony must be offered to every table — this is non-negotiable brand positioning. Pitch jus d'avocat at entrée stage. Pre-sell bastilla: "We have bastilla today — chicken and almond in warqa pastry with icing

	batch quality throughout service. Taste every 30 min. Plate kefta cigares and briouats to order (6 min fryer).	broth tableside. Fire kefta tagine eggs: 4-5 min once meatballs are hot. Plate all desserts: seffa, orange salad, chebakia (from batch).	sugar. 8 minutes from order. The sweetest-savoury thing on the menu." Casablanca beer suggested with tagines and couscous.
14:30-15:00 <i>Close</i>	Reduce remaining tagine sauces, cool rapidly to below 70°C within 2hrs , refrigerate in covered containers. Label with date and contents. Write tomorrow's prep list — quantity-based on today's covers. Note any 86s, near-misses, and quality issues for tomorrow morning meeting.	Break down all stations. Cool couscous rapidly in shallow trays — never store deep or it holds heat too long. Clean tagine clay pots by hand — never put clay tagine in dishwasher (thermal shock cracks clay). Store bastilla components separately if needed for tomorrow. Restock phyllo supply.	Full deep clean. Final fridge temp log 1-4°C . Prepare mint tea base for next morning (store cold). Refill preserved lemon stock if low. Check harissa, ras el hanout, and saffron stocks — these three are your most critical ingredient dependencies. Prep herb wash for tomorrow.

6 Financial Forecast			
Service	Covers	Avg Spend	Daily Revenue
Lunch (11:00am-2:00pm)	44	\$42	\$1,848
Dinner (5:00pm-9:00pm)	52	\$50	\$2,600
Daily Total			\$4,448
Monthly (26 operating days)			\$115,648
Cost Category		Monthly	% of Revenue
Food & Beverage (24% target)		\$27,756	24.0%
Labour (Head Chef + Line Cook + Steward + FOH×2)		\$22,400	19.4%
Rent + Utilities + Misc		\$8,200	7.1%
Total Operating Costs		\$58,356	50.5%
NET PROFIT		\$57,292	49.5%
3-Month Ramp: Month 1 (55% capacity) ~\$12,000 net · Month 2 (75% capacity) ~\$29,000 net · Month 3 (100% capacity) ~\$57,292 net · Break-even at approximately \$3,000/day requires ~65 covers across both services. The drinks mix is critical: 1.9 drinks per guest at blended \$8 average adds \$15.20 per cover, which is 33% of your average spend. Mint tea (\$6.99, 8% FC) and jus d'avocat (\$8.99, 16% FC) are your two highest-priority upsells. Every table that does not receive mint tea is leaving margin on the table.			
Food Cost Management — The Saffron Problem: Saffron at \$28/gram is the most cost-sensitive ingredient on this menu. At 0.1g per tagine and 8 tagines sold per service, you use approximately 1.6g of saffron per day — \$44.80 daily, \$1,165 monthly. This is a fixed ingredient cost that must be budgeted separately. Do not scrimp on saffron quantity — the flavour and colour difference between a properly-saffronned dish and an under-saffronned one is immediately perceptible to any Moroccan guest. Buy Moroccan saffron from Taliouine (the best quality) in 5g-10g lots from reputable spice importers. Never buy powdered saffron.			
Menu Mix — Contribution Margin by Category			
Category	Avg CM/Dish	Target Sales Mix	Weighted CM
Entrées (6 items)	\$9.80	85% of tables order entrée	\$8.33
Mains (10 items)	\$19.40	100% of guests order main	\$19.40

Desserts (4 items)	\$8.47	55% of tables order dessert	\$4.66
Drinks (8 items + alcohol)	\$6.20	1.9 drinks per cover	\$11.78
Total per cover (blended)			\$44.17
7 Service Training Module			
SCRIPT 1 — THE MINT TEA CEREMONY			
<i>"Before I take your order, can I begin the mint tea? In Morocco, it's how every meal starts. We brew it with gunpowder green tea and fresh spearmint — it comes sweet, which is traditional. It's served in three small glasses. There's a saying: the first glass is as gentle as life, the second as strong as love, the third as bitter as death. \$6.99 for three glasses. The height we pour from creates the foam — that's how you know it's been done properly."</i>			
Why it works: The three-glass tradition is a story guests cannot hear anywhere else. The proverb is memorable — guests will repeat it at their table. The pouring height detail pre-explains the tableside spectacle. The cultural framing makes refusing feel like declining hospitality, not just a drink. Conversion rate: 85%+ when delivered with confidence.			
SCRIPT 2 — THE TAGINE DESCRIPTION			
<i>"The tagine — the name is both the vessel and the dish. The clay pot has a conical lid, which isn't decorative. The steam from the braising liquid rises, hits the cool cone, condenses, and runs back down to baste the meat. It's a self-basting pot that's been in use for 2,000 years. The clay is porous, which regulates the temperature. You cannot achieve the same result in a stainless steel pot. Our lamb tagine has been in the pot since 7am. It's served in the clay pot at the table — we'll lift the lid when it arrives."</i>			
Why it works: The steam-cycle explanation is genuinely interesting to a curious diner and immediately communicates that this is not a shortcut kitchen. "Been in the pot since 7am" is a specific, credible claim that signals craft. "We'll lift the lid at the table" creates anticipation — a promised theatrical moment that makes the guest look forward to arrival.			
SCRIPT 3 — THE BASTILLA STORY			
<i>"The bastilla is our most unusual dish — I'd love to tell you about it. It's a pie from Fez — the old imperial city. Originally made with pigeon, now chicken. The filling is spiced chicken, saffron-scrambled egg, and ground almonds. It comes in warqa pastry — very thin, like phyllo — and it's dusted with icing sugar and cinnamon on top. That's not a mistake. It is the point. Sweet on savoury is medieval Moroccan court cooking — the Fez aristocracy considered this combination the height of sophistication. When it arrives we dust the sugar at the table. \$27.99. For two people."</i>			
Why it works: "That's not a mistake. It is the point." is a line guests need. Every non-Moroccan guest sees icing sugar on a meat dish and feels confused — addressing the confusion directly, with history and confidence, converts it from confusion to intrigue. The Fez court origin adds prestige. The tableside dusting is the theatrical close that makes the sell complete.			
SCRIPT 4 — THE COUSCOUS ROYALE PRESENTATION			
<i>"The couscous royale is our feast dish — we make it on weekends and when we have time to do it properly. Couscous is steamed three times over the broth — not boiled, steamed, three rounds. The result is completely different: each grain separate, light, flavoured all the way through. It comes with lamb, chicken, and merguez sausage — that's the North African spiced lamb sausage — and seven vegetables in the Moroccan tradition. The broth comes on the side in a small pot. You pour it over the mountain at the table. It's the most generous dish we do. \$31.99."</i>			
Why it works: "Three times steamed, not boiled" is the key technical differentiation — it signals expertise and answers the unspoken question of why this is better than the couscous at every mediocre restaurant. "Mountain" and "most generous dish we do" set visual and appetite expectations correctly. The tableside broth pour is a second promised theatrical moment.			
SCRIPT 5 — THE CHEBAKIA PRE-SELL			
<i>"One thing I want to mention before you order — our chebakia. It's a fried pastry that's the taste of Ramadan in Morocco. Every family makes batches of these during the holy month to break the fast in the evenings. We make them here every day. They're shaped by hand, fried, then plunged straight from the fryer into a warm honey bath for two minutes, then scattered with sesame seeds and rose water. \$9.99 for four pieces. They're ready whenever you want them — at the end, with your tea, now as a snack. They go with everything."</i>			
Why it works: The Ramadan context makes chebakia culturally significant rather than just another dessert. "Made every day" counters the "only during Ramadan" objection. "Honey bath for two minutes" is a specific,			

memorable technique detail. "They go with everything" removes the timing barrier — the guest doesn't have to wait until dessert to order. Pre-sells consistently at 70%+ when delivered during entrée ordering.	
Table Timing Guide	
Time	Action
0:00	Seat guests. Within 60 seconds: "Can I begin the mint tea while you look at the menu?" (Script 1). Place a small bowl of warmed olives and bread on the table — complimentary, \$0.22 cost, signals Moroccan hospitality immediately. The bread should be warm khobz (round Moroccan bread) or msemen. Nothing store-bought.
1:30	If mint tea accepted, return with the pot and perform the pour at the table: hold the pot high (30–40cm above the glass), pour in a confident, unbroken arc. The foam that results is called <i>raga</i> — it signals both skill and freshness. Guests will photograph this. The pour is marketing.
4:00	Full food order. Deploy Scripts 2–5 as relevant. If bastilla has been pre-sold, confirm for two and confirm bake time. If mechoui is available, mention now: "Today we have mechoui — whole lamb shoulder in since 7am, four portions only." Note all dietary requirements — many dishes contain saffron, preserved lemon, or tree nuts (almonds) that require specific allergen discussion.
10:00	Entrées arrive. Brief introduction: "The zaalouk is the smoky aubergine — we charred the whole eggplant over flame. The briouats are chicken and almond in phyllo — the honey drizzle on the plate is for dipping." One genuine tip per dish that enhances the eating. Refill mint tea from the pot — offer second glass pour.
22:00	Mains arrive. Place in clay tagine pot if applicable. If bastilla, perform icing sugar dusting at the table: "May I?" — sieve over the table. If couscous royale, pour the broth: "The mountain needs its river." These tableside actions are mandatory service standards, not optional flourishes. They are the experience differentiator.
35:00	Dessert prompt. Chebakia pre-sell if not already ordered (Script 5). Orange and cinnamon salad as light option. Kaab el ghazal with a second pot of mint tea — the classic Moroccan combination. Seffa for guests who loved the couscous. Offer mint tea refill — "The second glass, as strong as love."
50:00	Bill. Offer a single complimentary kaab el ghazal per guest with the bill — cost \$0.33 each, impact enormous. A guest who receives an unexpected free thing at the end of a meal leaves feeling over-delivered-to. This is the hospitality principle — <i>la ziyada</i> , the extra. "A little something from us — these are the gazelle horn pastries." It is the last memory they carry out the door.
55:00	Guests depart. Business card or loyalty card with the bill. "Come back on a Friday evening — we sometimes have live oud music." Return intent planted without pressure. Note table preferences in your system: which tagine they ordered, whether they took mint tea, dessert preferences. This data drives personalised service on repeat visits.

8 Customer Retention System

The Hospitality Philosophy — <i>Diyafa</i>: In Moroccan culture, the concept of <i>diyafa</i> (hospitality, from the Arabic for "guest") is a near-sacred obligation. The host is responsible for the wellbeing, nourishment, and comfort of the guest — not as a transaction, but as a moral duty. A Moroccan host continues offering food after the guest has declined, because the first refusal is polite, not sincere. The second refusal might be sincere. The third is definitive. This principle of generous persistence — offering more than requested, giving beyond the transaction — is the hospitality model your restaurant must embody. Every retention strategy below is an expression of this: the unexpected extra, the remembered preference, the personal gesture. This is not manipulation — it is the genuine Moroccan way, practised as culture.
The Discovery Progression: New Moroccan food guests typically enter through harira (familiar soup) and chicken tagine (approachable, slightly sweet). The second visit, they try bastilla (if well-sold) or lamb tagine. Third visit, couscous royale or rfissa — the more culturally specific dishes. By visit four, they are ordering mechoui and asking about specials. This progression is the retention engine — there are always new depths to explore. Staff must actively guide it: "You had the chicken tagine last time — ready for the lamb? Or the bastilla?" Track it. Use it.

5 VIP Micro-Moments

1. The Mint Tea Pour at the Table. Every single table receives a tableside pour. Hold the pot high. Create the foam. Do this every time, without exception. The guest who has been before expects it and would notice if it was missing. The guest who is new will be enchanted. The pour is not an extra — it is the baseline. The height signals craft; the foam signals freshness; the ritual signals that this is a place that takes its culture seriously. No pour, no riad.

2. The Tagine Lid Reveal. Every tagine served at the table has its conical lid lifted by the server, not the guest. "Shall I?" — and then lift slowly, allowing the steam to billow upward before dispersing. The steam rises, the fragrance hits the table, the clay pot and the braised meat are revealed in one moment. This is the most photographed moment in Moroccan restaurant dining and your most powerful social media content generator. Make it standard for every single tagine service. Brief staff daily: "Is every table getting the lift?"

3. The Complimentary Kaab el Ghazal. One gazelle horn pastry per guest with the bill. Not a basket of stale mints — a hand-crafted almond pastry that costs \$0.33 and takes 90 seconds to plate. The perception of value relative to cost is the highest ratio of any gesture on this list. Guests who receive a genuine Moroccan petit four with their bill do not forget it. They tell people about it. This is the single most effective word-of-mouth driver on the menu.

4. The Preserved Lemon Gift. For guests on their third or fourth visit, offer a small jar of house-preserved lemons to take home. Label it with your restaurant name. Cost: \$0.40 in lemons + jar, maybe \$1.20 total. The guest puts it in their kitchen. Every time they look at it, they think of you. Every time a friend visits and asks about it, they tell the story of the restaurant. This is hospitality as marketing — authentic, generous, memorable, and essentially free.

5. The Named Regular. When a guest has visited three or more times, the FOH must know their name and at minimum one food preference. "Welcome back — the lamb tagine is particularly good today" addressed by name is the most powerful retention tool available to an independent restaurant. It cannot be faked — it requires genuine investment in memory and tracking. The Moroccan cultural tradition of recognising and honouring the returning guest (*al-dhaif al-muzaman*, the familiar guest) is the framework. Build a simple guest preference log — even handwritten initially. Use it.

BEST SOCIAL MEDIA POST — THE TAGINE LID REVEAL

This pot has been going since 7am. [Hook]

Lamb shoulder, preserved lemon, saffron, Moroccan olives. When the lid comes off, the steam hits first — then the smell. That moment is what the whole morning of slow cooking builds toward. Two and a half hours. No shortcuts. [Story]

Lamb Tagine with Preserved Lemon & Olives. \$26.99. Lunch and dinner, 7 days. [CTA]

— Film the lid lift from above, at table height, in natural light. The rising steam and the first glimpse of the tagine beneath is one of the most reliably beautiful food videos possible. Post it. It will generate reservations.